

Cyber Threat Intelligence Advisory

Handala (Void Manticore) Weaponization of Mobile Device Management (MDM) Platforms

Traffic Light Protocol (TLP): AMBER

Analyst: Nora Asrar

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Purpose: Analysis of identity-based attacks leveraging Microsoft Intune to conduct enterprise-scale destructive operations.

This advisory was independently prepared using publicly available reporting for portfolio and educational purposes.

Executive Summary (BLUF)

Handala (also tracked as **Void Manticore** and **BANISHED KITTEN**) has shifted from traditional destructive malware toward the abuse of trusted cloud management infrastructure. Rather than relying solely on custom wiper malware, the group has reportedly leveraged compromised privileged identities to issue enterprise-scale remote wipe commands through Mobile Device Management (MDM) platforms such as Microsoft Intune [1][2].

This activity reflects a broader shift toward the abuse of legitimate cloud administration tools rather than traditional malware. By operating through trusted management platforms, attackers may reduce the effectiveness of security controls that primarily focus on malicious executables [2][5]. Organizations that rely heavily on cloud identity and centralized device management should prioritize identity security and administrative safeguards, as compromise of these platforms can enable widespread operational disruption.

Threat Actor Profile & Geopolitical Context

Attribution: Public reporting has linked Handala (Void Manticore/BANISHED KITTEN) to actors associated with the Iranian Ministry of Intelligence and Security (MOIS) [1][3].

Handala operates as a hacktivist-style front while exhibiting capabilities commonly associated with state-sponsored cyber operations. The group combines cyber intrusions with information

operations designed to maximize psychological impact, create public distrust, and disrupt critical services [1][3].

Observed Target Sectors

- Healthcare
- Defense Industrial Base (DIB)
- Energy
- Telecommunications
- Government
- Critical infrastructure across the MENA region and allied Western countries

Attack Lifecycle & MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Attack Phase	MITRE ATT&CK	Observed Activity
Initial Access	T1078, T1566	Adversary-in-the-Middle (AiTM) credential harvesting [2]
Persistence/Privilege	T1087, T1003	Active Directory enumeration using ADRecon and LSASS credential dumping [2]
Execution/Impact	T1651, T1485	Enterprise-scale Microsoft Intune remote wipe commands [2][4]

Analyst Assessment

What stands out about this campaign is the way destructive effects can be achieved without relying solely on custom malware. By compromising privileged identities and abusing trusted administrative platforms such as Microsoft Intune, attackers can use legitimate enterprise capabilities to cause widespread disruption while making their actions resemble authorized administrative activity.

As organizations continue moving device management and identity services to the cloud, privileged accounts have become especially valuable targets. A single compromised administrative identity can provide access to capabilities that affect an entire managed environment, making identity security just as important as protecting individual endpoints.

This, in turn, highlights the need for organizations to look beyond traditional endpoint defenses. Strengthening identity security, limiting privileged access, and monitoring cloud administration activity are becoming increasingly important as threat actors continue to abuse legitimate tools to achieve their objectives.

Key Assessment

Organizations should assume that cloud administration platforms will remain attractive targets and prioritize controls that reduce both the likelihood and potential impact of privileged identity compromise.

Recommended Defensive Actions

Restrict High-Risk Administrative Actions

Require Just-in-Time (JIT) privileged access and multi-admin approval for destructive actions such as device wipes. Microsoft and Deepwatch both identify privileged access controls and multi-admin approval as key safeguards for Intune administration [2][6].

Enhance Behavioral Monitoring

Develop SIEM detections for anomalous management platform activity, including:

- Large volumes of remote wipe requests
- Sudden increases in Microsoft Graph API activity
- Administrative actions originating from unusual locations or impossible travel scenarios
- New privileged role assignments immediately preceding management actions

Strengthen Identity Security

Implement phishing-resistant authentication for all privileged accounts through hardware-backed FIDO2 security keys or equivalent phishing-resistant MFA methods. Reduce standing administrative privileges through role-based access control and Privileged Identity Management (PIM) [2].

Improve Incident Response Readiness

Establish documented response procedures for cloud identity compromise, including rapid credential revocation, privileged account containment, conditional access policy enforcement, and recovery of managed devices following unauthorized administrative actions.

Key Takeaways

- Legitimate cloud management platforms can be weaponized to produce destructive effects

- Compromise of privileged cloud identities can create enterprise-wide operational impact
- Endpoint-focused defenses alone may not provide sufficient visibility into management-plane abuse
- Identity hardening, administrative safeguards, and behavioral monitoring should be treated as core defensive priorities

References

[1] Check Point Research. (2026, March 12). "Handala Hack" - Unveiling Group's Modus Operandi. research.checkpoint.com

[2] Deepwatch Adversary Tactics and Intelligence Team. (2026, March 23). CA-A-26-004: Iranian-Nexus Handala Group's Microsoft Intune Wiping Tactics. deepwatch.com

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[4] Microsoft Learn. (2026). managedDevice: wipe action - Microsoft Graph v1.0. learn.microsoft.com

[5] Microsoft Learn. (2026). Device actions in Microsoft Intune. learn.microsoft.com

[6] Microsoft Learn. Use access policies to require multi-admin approval in Microsoft Intune. learn.microsoft.com

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